escorted you to the front door. But no, I was never given any warnings. Believe it or not, I was actually very disciplined and observant of the rules when I was at Harmony.

There was even a girl I knew at the clinic – a pretty Italian girl I'd met a couple of times at Caprice, a bar in Camps Bay. Lovely girl … and I couldn't even talk to her. Until the last day of my stay, that is. The day I was due to leave, I said, 'You guys can warn me all you want. This is my last day. I'm going to flipping talk to her.'

The rest of a routine morning was taken up by lectures and written work, as well as some group meetings. After lunch, we sometimes attended meetings outside the clinic … Alcoholics Anonymous, for example. For me, this was probably the hardest thing to do. Once, sometimes twice a week, I'd have to stand up and utter that well-known line: 'Hi, my name is Herschelle and I'm an alcoholic …'

Not only was it embarrassing – this wasn't within the protective and safe confines of the clinic – but I didn't even believe what I was saying. I knew I had to say the words in order to sort out my issues, but I didn't, and still don't, believe that I am an alcoholic. I simply don't buy into the notion that getting fall-down drunk a couple of times a year means that you're an alcoholic. Still, there I was, standing up and saying those words every week.

At these meetings, once everyone had introduced themselves and the 'chairman' had said a few words, the floor was opened to everyone. You're not allowed to speak if it is your first meeting, but even at subsequent meetings I didn't say much. I preferred to listen. Some of the stories you'd hear … jeez man, they were mind-blowing. I didn't think it was humanly possible to drink as much as some of those people did.

One guy basically drank away the entire value of his house in the space of six months. Mind-boggling stuff. And that did hit me quite hard. I was given a glimpse of how my life could turn out if I didn't slow down.

Another guy told us how he'd shot and killed his brother when he was high. He still doesn't know why he did it. Just shot him. I mean, I could relate to these stories, as I was going down that same road. I would drink so much that I'd have blackouts, and the next day I wouldn't have a bladdy clue what I had done the night before. As I talk about this, it's been nearly two years since rehab … and memories of those meetings are still very fresh in my mind.